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“Free” Surveillance Tech Still Comes at a High and Dangerous Cost

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Surveillance [technology](#) vendors, federal agencies, and wealthy private donors have long helped provide local law enforcement “free” access to surveillance equipment that bypasses local oversight. The result is predictable: serious accountability gaps and data pipelines to other entities, including [Immigration and Customs Enforcement \(ICE\)](#), that expose millions of people to harm.

The cost of “free” surveillance tools — like [automated license plate readers](#) (ALPRs), networked cameras, [face recognition](#), drones, and [data aggregation and analysis platforms](#) — is measured not in tax dollars, but in the erosion of civil liberties.

The collection and sharing of our data quietly generates detailed records of people’s movements and associations that can be exposed, hacked, or repurposed without their knowledge or consent. Those records [weaken sanctuary](#) and First Amendment protections while facilitating the targeting of vulnerable people.

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Cities can and should use their power to reject federal grants, vendor trials, donations from wealthy individuals, or participation in partnerships that facilitate surveillance and experimentation with spy tech.

If these projects are greenlit, oversight is imperative. Mechanisms like public hearings, competitive bidding, public records transparency, and city council supervision aid to ensure these acquisitions include basic safeguards — like use policies, audits, and consequences for misuse — to protect the public from abuse and from creeping contracts that grow into [whole suites](#) of products.

Clear policies and oversight mechanisms must be in place *before* using any surveillance tools, free or not, and communities and their elected officials must be at the center of every decision about whether to bring these tools in at all.

Here are some of the most common methods “free” surveillance tech makes its way into communities.

Trials and Pilots

Police departments are regularly offered free access to surveillance tools and software through trials and pilot programs that often aren’t accompanied by appropriate use policies. In many jurisdictions, trials do not trigger the same requirements to go before decision-makers outside the police department. This means the public [may have no idea](#) that a pilot program for [surveillance technology](#) is happening in their city.

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In Denver, Colorado, the police department is running trials of possible unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs) for a drone-as-first-responder (DFR) program from two competing drone vendors: [Flock Safety Aerodome drones](#) (through August 2026) and [drones from the company Skydio](#), partnering with Axon, the multi-billion dollar police technology company behind tools like Tasers and [AI-generated police reports](#). Drones create unique issues given their vantage for capturing private property and unsuspecting civilians, as well as their capacity to [make other technologies, like ALPRs](#), airborne.

Functional, Even Without Funding

We've seen cities decide not to fund a tool, or run out of funding for it, only to have a company continue providing it in the hope that money will turn up. [This happened in Fall River, Massachusetts](#), where the police department decided not to fund ShotSpotter's [\\$90,000 annual cost](#) and its frequent false alarms, but continued using the system when the company provided free access.

Police technology companies are developing more features and subscription-based models, so what's "free" today frequently results in taxpayers footing the bill later.

In May 2025, [Denver's city council unanimously rejected a \\$666,000 contract extension](#) for Flock Safety ALPR cameras after weeks of public outcry over mass surveillance [data sharing with federal immigration enforcement](#). But Mayor Mike Johnston's office allowed the cameras to keep running through a "task force" review, effectively extending the program even after the contract was voted down. In response, the Denver Taskforce to Reimagine Policing and Public Safety and [Transforming Our Communities Alliance launched a grassroots campaign](#) demanding the city "[turn Flock cameras off now](#)," a reminder that when surveillance starts as a pilot or time-limited contract, communities often have to fight not just to block renewals but to shut the systems off.

Importantly, police technology companies are developing [more features](#) and subscription-based models, so what's "free" today frequently results in taxpayers footing the bill later.

Gifts from Police Foundations and Wealthy Donors

Police foundations and the wealthy have pushed surveillance-driven agendas in their local communities by donating equipment and making large monetary gifts, another means of acquiring these tools without public oversight or buy-in.

In Atlanta, the Atlanta Police Foundation (APF) attempted to use its position as a private entity to circumvent transparency. Following a court challenge from [the Atlanta Community Press Collective and Lucy Parsons Labs](#), a Georgia court determined that the APF must comply with public records laws related to some of its actions and purchases on behalf of law enforcement.

In San Francisco, billionaire Chris Larsen has [financially supported a supercharging of the city's surveillance infrastructure](#), donating \$9.4 million to fund the San Francisco Police Department's (SFPD) Real-Time Investigation Center, where a menu of surveillance technologies and data come together to surveil the city's residents. This move comes after the billionaire [backed a ballot measure](#), which passed in March 2025, eroding the city's surveillance technology law and allowing the SFPD free rein to use new surveillance technologies for a [full year without oversight](#).

Free Tech for Federal Data Pipelines

Federal grants and Department of Homeland Security funding are another way surveillance technology appears free to, only to lock municipalities into [long-term data-sharing](#) and recurring costs.

Through the [Homeland Security Grant Program](#), which includes the State Homeland Security Program (SHSP) and the Urban Areas Security (UASI) Initiative, and Department of Justice programs like [Byrne JAG](#), the federal government reimburses states and cities for "homeland security" equipment and software, including including law-enforcement surveillance tools, analytics platforms, and real-time crime centers. Grant guidance and vendor marketing materials make clear that these funds can be used for automated license plate readers, integrated video surveillance and analytics systems, and centralized command-center software—in other words, purchases framed as counterterrorism investments but deployed in everyday policing.

Vendors have learned to design products around this federal money, pitching ALPR networks, camera systems, and analytic platforms as "grant-ready" solutions that can be acquired with little or no upfront local cost. [Motorola Solutions](#), for example, advertises how SHSP and UASI dollars can be used for "law enforcement surveillance equipment" and "video surveillance, warning, and access control" systems. Flock Safety, [partnering with Lexipol](#), a company that writes use policies for law enforcement, offers a "License Plate Readers Grant Assistance Program" that helps police departments identify federal and state grants and tailor their applications to fund ALPR projects.

Grant assistance programs let police chiefs fast-track new surveillance: the paperwork is outsourced, the grant eats the upfront cost, and even when there is a formal paper trail, the practical checks from residents, councils, and procurement rules often get watered down or bypassed.

On paper, these systems arrive "for free" through a federal grant; in practice, they lock cities into recurring software, subscription, and data-hosting fees that quietly turn into permanent budget lines—and a lasting surveillance infrastructure—as soon as police and prosecutors start to rely on them. In [Santa Cruz, California](#), the police department explicitly sought to use a DHS-funded SHSP grant to pay for a new citywide network of Flock ALPR cameras at the city's entrances and exits, with local funds covering additional cameras. In [Sumner, Washington](#), a \$50,000 grant was used to cover the entire first year of a Flock system — including installation and maintenance — after which the city is on the hook for roughly \$39,000 every year in ongoing fees. The free grant money opens the door, but local governments are left with years of financial, political, and permanent surveillance entanglements they never fully vetted.

The most dangerous cost of this "free" funding is not just budgetary; it is the way it ties local systems into federal data pipelines. Since 9/11, DHS has used these grant streams to build a nationwide network of at least [79–80 state and regional fusion centers](#) that integrate and share data from federal, state, local, tribal, and private partners. Research shows that state fusion centers rely heavily on the DHS Homeland Security Grant Program (especially SHSP and UASI) to "mature their capabilities," with [some centers reporting](#) that 100 percent of their annual expenditures are covered by these grants.

Civil rights investigations have documented how this funding architecture creates a backdoor channel for ICE and other federal agencies to access local surveillance data for their own purposes. A recent report by the Surveillance Technology Oversight Project (S.T.O.P.) [describes](#) ICE agents using a

Philadelphia-area fusion center to query the city's ALPR network to track undocumented drivers in a self-described sanctuary city.

Ultimately, federal grants follow the same script as trials and foundation gifts: what looks “free” ends up costing communities their data, their sanctuary protections, and their power over how local surveillance is used.

Protecting Yourself Against “Free” Technology

The most important protection against "free" surveillance technology is to reject it outright. Cities [do not have to accept](#) federal grants, vendor trials, or philanthropic donations. Saying no to "free" tech is not just a policy choice; it is a political power that local governments possess and can exercise. Communities and their elected officials can and should refuse surveillance systems that arrive through federal grants, vendor pilots, or private donations, regardless of how attractive the initial price tag appears.

For those cities that have already accepted surveillance technology, the imperative is equally clear: shut it down. When a community has rejected use of a spying tool, the capabilities, equipment, and data collected from that tool should be shut off immediately. Full stop.

And for any surveillance technology that remains in operation, even temporarily, there must be clear rules: when and how equipment is used, how that data is retained and shared, who owns data and how companies can access and use it, transparency requirements, and consequences for any misuse and abuse.

“Free” surveillance technology is never free. Someone profits or gains power from it. Police technology vendors, federal agencies, and wealthy donors do not offer these systems out of generosity; they offer them because surveillance serves their interests, not ours. That is the real cost of “free” surveillance.

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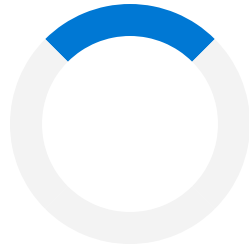
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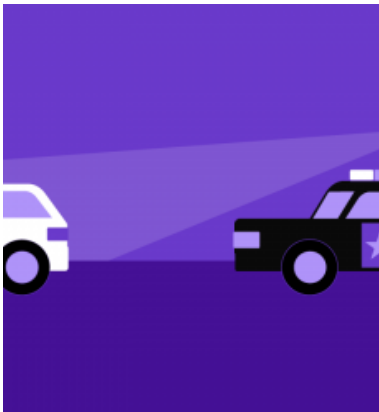


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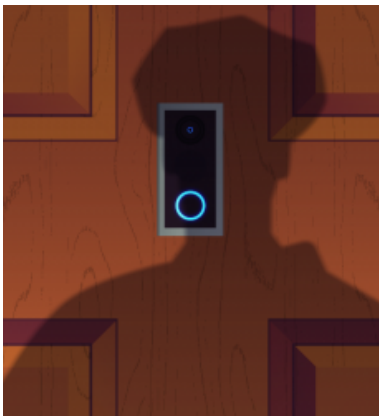
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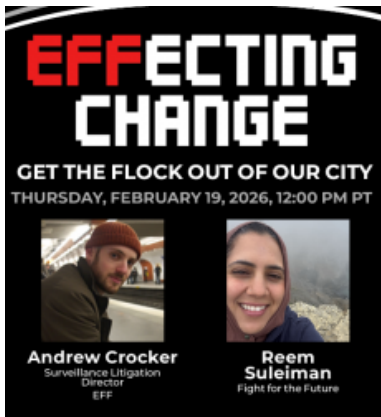
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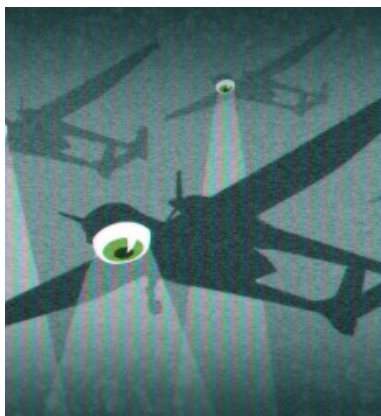
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